

Tony relates, “As the new master I wasn’t very good at traversing through the Five Whys effectively, and the problems we were trying to solve were not great candidates in the first place. As you can imagine, these early sessions were awkward and in the end not very useful. I was getting quite discouraged and frustrated.” This is a common problem when one tries to tackle too much at once, but it is also a consequence of the fact that these skills take time to master. Luckily, Tony persevered: “Having a Five Whys master is critical in my opinion. Five Whys is easy in theory but difficult in practice, so you need someone who knows it well to shape the sessions for those who don’t.”

The turnaround came when Tony led a Five Whys session involving a project that had been missing its deadlines. The session was fascinating and insightful and produced meaningful proportional investments. Tony explains: “The success had to do with a more experienced master and more experienced attendees. We all knew what the Five Whys was, and I did a really good job keeping us on track and away from tangents. This was a pivotal moment. Right then I knew the Five Whys was a new tool that was going to have a real impact on our overall success as a team and as a business.”

On the surface, Five Whys seems to be about technical problems and preventing mistakes, but as teams drive out these superficial wastes, they develop a new understanding of how to work together. Tony put it this way: “I daresay that I discovered that the Five Whys transcends root cause analysis by revealing information that brings your team closer through a common understanding and perspective. A lot of times a problem can pull people apart; Five Whys does the opposite.”

I asked Tony to provide an example of a recent successful Five Whys analysis from IGN. His account of it is listed in the sidebar.

Why couldn't you add or edit posts on the blogs?

Answer: Any post request (write) to the article content api was